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Author:
Frank Smith

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Ringing

A Dramatic Monologue

Written by Frank Smith

SCENE I

Ezra's Apartment.

(Spartan. No art, no posters, no personality. Yet 100% clean. Not one dust speck on one surface.)

EZRA.

(EZRA NEWELL (32), even in sweats, he looks crisp and sharp, sits at a table, drinking coffee. He points to a second cup.)

EZRA: For you. I told Chief, you guys don't have to come check on me. I'm a detective. I'm tough. I've just, I don't know, been through it these last few weeks. The Ramos case took a lot out of me. I really thought we were going to find that kid, you know? You do what we do long enough, and you get an instinct for how things are going to turn out. That case had "this kid's hiding out somewhere" written all over it. Ran away from home all the time. Whenever he fought with his big brother. But there was love there. They needed each other. Little guy, getting taken right off the street like that. Wouldn't have happened if his big brother had been looking after him, like he was supposed to. They're all victims. I know that. I just never would let someone I truly loved out of my sight like that. You never know what could happen.

(Ezra goes to take another sip of coffee, then pushes it away.)

EZRA: Here. Take it. I can't have this. I'm pretty wired already. You know, I don't know how I'd be able to do any of this if it weren't for Amory. He really is the one for me. Which is crazy, because cops and teachers, all we really have in common is unions. That's not true: he and I, we both love kids. I think that was the big thing that drew us together. I love protecting kids. He loves teaching kids. Plus, we first met while helping a kid find her Mom in the park. You know that story, right? Wait. I've never told you? Then you're in for a treat. Well, I was doing my usual morning workout in the park. Because I'm a fan of the outdoors. Not because I was throwing out a fishing line. AKA my abs. Anyway. He was jogging by. But I felt like he kept doing laps near my area in particular. And not just 'cause it was "part of his routine." I'm about to get my flirt on, when I hear this little girl crying. Curly hair. Striped dress. Says she has no idea where her Mom went. The dog ran off, and she hasn't come back yet. I'm guessing this means she's only been gone a few minutes – I remember being a kid and having no sense of time – but still, I go to hold her hand, and walk her around, to look for her Mom. That's when I see someone else has taken her hand at the same time. Amory. Kind, sweaty, handsome, helpful. Just like me. We introduce ourselves to this little girl, and then to each other. Her mother is so grateful, when we find her looking for her daughter nearby. Says she really appreciates us, and we make a cute couple. I agree. Which is why I ask him out. And he immediately says yes.

(Ezra pours one cup of coffee into another.)

EZRA: Seriously, have this! I don't want it. You know how hard it is to find a partner who gets it. The long nights. The secret cases. The mood swings. What we do gets to us, and them. It's not for everybody. When we win, and help families out, it's amazing. But when we don't – well. Amory gets it. He wants great results for his kids, just like we do. I've had a lot of boyfriends who couldn't handle the unpredictability of what I do. The stress of what I do. The risk of what I do. But he always understood. From the start.

(Ezra pours out both coffees in the sink.)

EZRA: I'm lucky. I can barely remember ever having an argument with him, to be honest. Well, I guess that's not completely true. There was definitely at least one time. The only time, I think. I came home in tears, from a case I hadn't been able to crack. Little girl named Shannon Brown. Wonderful parents, wonderful siblings, wonderful home. Just didn't make any sense. Sometimes, this world of ours is unfair. Turn away for a second, and everything changes. Like losing your little girl. The light of your life. At least when there's death, there's closure. You know? But that wasn't something this family ever got, or seemed like they would get. Nothing on CCTV. No eyewitness accounts. Just a missing, presumed dead, little girl. And I couldn't help it. Once I ran out of leads, and apologized to the family for not being able to help more, I came home, and just sobbed at the kitchen table. For hours and hours and hours. So many hours, actually, that I missed out on Amory getting a teaching award from his school. He came home, sat down, and put his arm around me. Said how sorry he was to see me sad like this. But he also said, "I'm disappointed you weren't able to come tonight." "Disappointed." The word a parent uses with a misbehaving child. And the tone – ooh. I've spoken to his classes about what I do before. It was definitely his teacher tone that he used when telling the kids to pay attention, or settle down. And, you know, it wasn't a tone that he typically used with me. But that's all he said. He kissed me on the head, went to bed, and didn't bring it up again. I know it sounds weird to count that as a fight, but for us – it was. I always meant to make it up to him somehow, but work kept getting in the way. Now, I know, for sure, that I didn't. I didn't ever make it up to him.

(Ezra eyes the cups.)

EZRA: I'm tired all of a sudden. I probably shouldn't have poured those out. But I think there might be more coffee in the pot.

(Ezra pours himself another cup of coffee, and takes a sip. He smiles.)

EZRA: I guess I did need that. Why don't we tell ourselves the truth about things like that? Right. It's time I let you in on something else. It's not just the Ramos case that has me down. Amory and I had an incredible dinner last week. New French place, Mes Amis? The steak is…wow. Never tasted anything like it. And the fries? Best I've ever had. All they had on the menu, steak and fries. All they needed. We came home, laughing, and smiling after a big bottle of wine. Said we'd have to do that again soon. But we haven't gone back yet. Because – damn, this is hard – Amory has been missing since that night, two weeks ago. I woke up, alone, and just thought he'd gone to work early, like always. Believe it or not, teachers sometimes start even earlier than detectives do. But when I came home, he wasn't back. Didn't respond to my texts all day long. That was odd, but I figured, hey, maybe it was some parent-teacher conference day, or academic development thing I'd forgotten all about. Because I remember a lot of things…most things…but not everything. But once it got to midnight – I knew something was wrong. I was sure he was missing. And I know our rules, 48 hours, so I figured I was on my own for finding him. Yes, I know you would have had my back, but…this felt like something I could totally handle. I do this for a living. Finding missing people. I know how to make this happen. And I didn't want to come into work, and make it seem like I didn't have my house in order. So, I started trying to find him, alone. Because I was alone. And I hadn't been in a really long time.

(Ezra takes another sip of coffee.)

EZRA: The first thing I had to do was sit down and wait for the ringing in my ears to go away. I have this thing, ever since I got into a shootout 2 years back. You remember. I didn't get shot – I wasn't that cool – but a bullet flew past my ear, while I was chasing down a suspect. I went to the ER, came out with hearing damage. So now, whenever I get into a stressful situation – even if it's just personal stress, and not physical – I have to sit down, and wait it out. Tinnitus, is what it's called. Chief told me I could go to a therapist to deal with that, but I don't like to have time to go boohoo to some therapist. No offense. How are things with Dr. Lily?

(Ezra winces, and grips his head.)

EZRA: Yep, there it is. Just need to give it a few seconds, and it'll go away. Ooh. This one is lasting a little longer than usual. Okay. Okay. It's gone. Whew. Right. So, I started the search for Amory. I followed the usual protocol. Went to the school. Talked to his teacher's aide, Jenna - or Joanne, I think it was. I don't remember. I mean, I've met her a bunch of times, so I really should know, at this point, but…yeah, I don't know. I've never really been that good with names. I am reliant on my notepad to remember every last witness. That's not true, actually. Witnesses, I can remember just fine. Civilians, normal people – they're in and out. Right, so back to…J name. She hasn't seen Amory since the day before. So, I go talk to the principal to ask some questions. And she didn't really know what had happened to him, either. Don't ask me for her name - I seriously don't know what it is. But the principal's secretary says that Amory, or someone who sounded like him, at least, called in to request a leave of absence, one day earlier. So that got me really, really worried. Look, I know Amory's not a kid, you know? But adults get taken all the time. Still, he knew how to be safe. We'd been together for years. So none of this, any of it, was making any kind of sense to me.

(Amory gets up and starts pacing.)

EZRA: I had to dig a little deeper. I called his family. They weren't answering any of my calls – and I called a lot – which of course made me immediately think that they had something to do with it. His brother Francis, you know, the suit salesman with the really bad taste? He was the one who liked me best out of all them. No, he doesn't know that I think his suits are bad. And even if he did, I think he'd still be polite. Anyway, I went to talk to him, Francis. Probably says something that I can remember men's names better than women's names. Guess I am gay after all. Well, Francis, he seemed really concerned. But all he said to me was, "I would leave it alone." Leave it alone? Leave it alone? I would not leave it alone. What did that even mean, "leave it alone?" That someone in his family had done something to Amory? "Leave it alone." That's like something you hear in a mob movie. Had Amory's family hurt him? Were a few of them in on it together? He was only a teacher, but he was the only one in his family who worked consistently, so he was worth the most money. I know all this sounds like a conspiracy. I know that. But some conspiracies are proven right in the end. I just didn't understand why this all wasn't easier. Didn't I track down missing people for a living? Missing people to whom I had no connection, at all? Why, when I loved the person who was missing, could I not find even a clue?

(Ezra grips his head a moment, and sits down, till the feeling goes away.)

EZRA: Don't get me wrong. This was starting to feel like something that I wanted to bring up to you all. But my gut told me it wasn't quite time yet. There was still an answer I could find on my own. And if I can do something without help – I want to. Amory wasn't like that. He wanted to do everything together, even complain. But that's not me, I told him. I think he understood. Anyway, I ran all of Amory's records I could think of: his car records, his credit card records, his phone records. Heck, even his old stereo records. Backwards and forwards. Anything that could give me a lead on where he was. It was the weirdest thing. I got nothing. Nada. Zip. None of my research turned up anything, at all. I was stuck. For maybe the first time in my career, I had no idea what to do next. But as you know, whenever your ingenuity fails you – luck fills in. I went to pay off my credit card – Amory's and my joint one – and that's when I saw that he, or whoever had his card, had already paid it off. And that really scared me. I checked the card's location – five towns over – so I got to roadtripping. I drove down this lonely country road for what felt like 100 miles. I could have sworn I was driving for days. Finally, I pulled into a long driveway. That's where I found his car. Now, I'm thinking, "Oh my God. Someone stole his car. Someone killed him. And I'm about to find my boyfriend's dead body inside this lonely house."

(Ezra takes a deep breath in, holding his head, before continuing.)

EZRA: I draw my weapon and run up to the door. I kick it in, and there's a loud scream coming from…Amory. It's him. He's there. He's alive. But, but, how is that even possible? Amory is okay…and he does not look happy to see me. Amory asks, "Ezra? What the hell are you doing here?" "What am I doing here?" I ask. "What are you doing here? I thought you were dead. I thought you were missing. I thought you…" "Amory," Ezra cuts in, "Did it ever occur to you that maybe I didn't want to be found?" No. No, it didn't. "I thought you were dead, Amory." All he said was, "I wish I were." I couldn't even see straight. I thought, what does that mean, you wish you were dead? And that's when the truth finally came out: that Amory had been miserable for a very long time. So miserable, he hadn't even known how to tell me. When he tried to explain, I never seemed to understand. Or didn't remember after. He knew my job as a finder of people meant he couldn't get away. And even despite all that, he had still tried to disappear, to even have a hope of ending our relationship. Because he knew I wouldn't give up, if he just broke up with me, like a normal person. Because apparently, I'm not a normal person. But being the great person that he is, he still didn't want to leave me with a bill to pay it off, not realizing that I'd be able to track his every movement. Like I always could. "Amory…we really can't work this out?" I asked. Begged, really. "Ezra," he said, "Do you even know what today is?"

(Ezra finishes the coffee incredibly slowly.)

EZRA: It was my own birthday. Not his. Mine. I got so wrapped up in finding him. I got so wrapped up in finding people, finding truth, that I didn't remember that it was my own Birthday. And if I couldn't remember things for myself – well, no wonder he felt ignored. And unloved. I left Amory at the house. He ran away. I guess I did a number on him. Which doesn't surprise me, because I also did a number on myself. And that's what I'm going to have to work on from now on. That ringing in my ears. It apparently echoes away with time, but it's something you actively have to work on. So, I guess that means that I'm going to take care of it. I have to take care of it.

THE END.